Mobile worms
Self replicating code that automatically spreads from one phone to another.

Mobile phishing
A fraudulent text message that lures people to reveal passwords, financial details or other private data

as of 2008, 90.34 per cent of mobile malware targets the Symbian platform, 4.14 per cent Windows Mobile, 3.35 per cent Palm OS, and 2.07 per cent targets J2ME.

Both networks and manufacturers soon realised the impending threat and steps were taken back then to stem the proliferation. Apple for instance, when it launched the iPhone, came up with the App Store so that trojans couldn't creep in through non-trusted third-party applications. Both Nokia and RIM have followed; creating their own app stores. Yet, people continue to jail break their phones or indiscriminately install any application that could perhaps hold trojans.

We asked Amit Nath, Country Manager, Trend Micro India & SAARC to tell us about the most problematic threat that they've encountered so far. He said, "Trend Micro researchers have encountered a fair number of mobile threats in the past two years, but

WINCE_INFOJACK has similar capabilities to the most dangerous information-stealing malware seen on the desktop. The worm targets the Windows Mobile PocketPC and runs on a Windows CE environment and steals information like the serial number, OS version, model, platform, and host's name then relays it to the malware author

it would be a stretch to call any of them *except one* anything truly problematic. The one exception we're referring to is WINCE_INFOJACK, which has similar capabilities to the most dangerous information-stealing malware seen on the desktop. More recently Trend Micro researchers detected malware targeting the Windows Mobile PocketPC. Detected as WINCE_INFOJACK.A, the worm runs on a Windows CE environment and steals information like the serial number, OS version, model, platform, and host's name then relays it to the malware author. WINCE_INFOJACK.A also changes security settings on the affected phone. The worm originates from an infected memory card on a mobile device or through SMS. In addition, another very recent virus attack was "Curse of Silence" virus. This denial-of-service attack prevents incoming SMSes from reaching the inbox once the user receives a specially formulated text message".

Phones affected by CurseSMS required a factory reset. Another important virus report of recent times was of the appearance of the first iPhone Trojan – a crude piece of code, with no means of propagation, purportedly written by a twelve year old.

Why isn't there a big boss virus yet?

Having noted all the outbreaks so far, there has not been a single major catastrophic virus event of the likes of Mellissa or Conficker in the PC world. Why is this so? According to recent research the reason is fragmentation in the market. Viruses will pose a serious threat only once a single mobile operating system's market share grows sufficiently large. For now, different vendors use different operating systems and so just as compatibility is an issue with applications so it is with viruses. A virus written for one OS will not work on another. A virus friendly eco-system is just what will happen in the near future given the existence of the iPhone OS and strong contender Android. The Palm Web OS is also being hailed as a thoroughbred multitasker. The impending popularity and proliferation of these operating systems will likely bring in the era of wide-spread mobile viruses. Yet another issue regarding the spread of viruses needs to be addressed here. The transmission mode or vectors. So far we have seen viruses that have spread through Bluetooth primarily. This is also a reason that no virus outbreak is very widespread. For a virus to be spread through Bluetooth it needs to be within a 10 to 30 meter radius of another Bluetooth enabled phone. MMS proliferating viruses are not so restricted in their spread. Like computer viruses they spread using the address book of the device and a network connection. The bad news is that hybrid viruses are also conceivable and these will pose the most significant threat.

What does the future hold?

Thieves will always go where there is money. Now that people have begun transacting business on their phones there is sure to be a surge in spyware written for mobile platforms. Around the end of last year a new report on emerging threats from the Georgia Tech Information Security Center mentioned that botnets are going to hit cell phones by mid-2009. Even if operating systems are different, browsers are still common. You have Opera Mini